



Album Release Plan Timeline Suggestion

There is no “one way” to doing pretty much anything in this industry – and like shoes, *one size doesn’t fit all*. This release plan below is one suggestion of many, but it is intended to give you a general idea of *one way* that you can aim to do things. You only have one chance to release an album – so put effort in but remember to enjoy the process.

In the best-case scenario you have a booking agent and record label (or publicist, radio promoter, streaming promoter, etc.) to support you through your release, but we aren’t going to get into label or agent discussions here and you could very well be well-equipped to do it all on your own. But I will say that if you are signed to label, it’s more likely that the timeline below won’t reflect what they will offer you. There are likely more moving parts, and you’ll more likely start planning your album much farther in advance.

AT ALL TIMES — BUILD YOUR MEDIA LIST

- Ask venues for their media lists when you perform there
- Search radio stations, newspapers, magazines city by city and collect emails
- Network
- For Canadians: search for Polaris Jurors contact info <http://polarismusicprize.ca/jury/>
- Submit to HARO
- Search LinkedIn
- Search social media
- Attend conferences
- Search the panelists names of conferences that include media personnel
- Search the publicists for artists similar to your sound

As I’m sure you’ve noticed by now after reading this book, it’s always better to build relationships with industry personnel in person or through connections made through friends and colleagues, but I understand this isn’t always easy or possible. So on the other hand, it is acceptable to send your music to media personnel via email when you don’t know them and ensure that they’ve received it, but then leave them alone (for the most part). You can check in once in a while, but only to update them on something new and exciting with your music career.

ENTIRE PRODUCTION PERIOD — CREATE AWARENESS

- Share pictures, video clips, and rough mixes from the studio. Share anything you can relating to your release and behind the scenes, that doesn’t give too much away.



12 – 6 MONTHS AHEAD — BEGIN THE BRAINSTORMING & COST SOURCING

- Your tour!! You MUST tour to support the release of the album
- Plan the release of a full LP – it's more ideal to release one right off the bat
- Radio, newspaper and TV interviews/performances in each city of your tour
- Professional photo shoot dates and concepts
- Album cover and other album art concepts
- Hard copy CD and vinyl production, distribution and storage
- Digital single release and full digital album release
- Merchandise design, production, distribution and storage
- Online sales, pre-sales, free singles, and contests
- Creative video content (e.g. post teaser videos on YouTube, Instagram and Facebook to announce the coming release)
- Marketing plan including email blasts, schedule social promotion and other promotions
- Album release / album listening party

4 – 3 MONTHS AHEAD — PRINT MEDIA

- Submit your music and album release plans to long-lead PRINT media such as magazines.

4 MONTHS AHEAD (of album release) 1 MONTH AHEAD (of single release) — HYPE UP DIGITAL SINGLE RELEASE + SET UP SINGLE DISTRIBUTION

- Release a single first like the pros do – especially if your fans are BEGGING for new music
- Share a digital poster with release date of single (and release date of LP)
- Host a count-down, host pre-sales, get creative
- Use a service like [TuneCore](#) (I used TuneCore and have no complaints) to distribute your music to all digital stores and streaming services for you

4 – 3 MONTHS AHEAD — ACQUIRE CD's and VINYL

- Be sure to give yourself a good couple of months lead time on acquiring the physical copies in the case of delays
- Once you HAVE THEM IN YOUR HANDS, then book your release party

4 – 3 MONTHS AHEAD — SET UP DISTRIBUTION

- Use a service like CD Baby or [TuneCore](#) (smarturl.it/e-tunecore) to distribute your music to all digital stores and streaming services for you, as well as source a physical distribution service (TuneCore will only take a few weeks MAX to get your music online –



but you can schedule the official release for a later date and host pre-sales).

3 – 2 MONTHS AHEAD — ONLINE MEDIA & RADIO

- Begin sending your music and album release plans to: podcasts, websites, bloggers, and social pages
- Begin shopping your single to radio stations as soon as you release it
- Commercial and satellite radio
- CBC for Canadians

3 – 2 MONTHS AHEAD — DIGITAL SINGLE RELEASE

- Release the catchiest single to streaming services and iTunes 2 months ahead of your album release date (my suggestion is to do this through TuneCore as mentioned above)
- Include the date of the full album release if you have it nailed down

2 – 1 MONTHS AHEAD — HYPE FOR RELEASE PARTY

- Start putting posters up around town
- Make it a special event
- Promote it like hell online
- Host a count-down
- Host a contest or giveaways

3 WEEKS AHEAD — MEDIA & RADIO FOLLOW UP

If they haven't already written about you or responded to your notes this might be a good reminder. Put them on the guest list and confirm that they will show up to your release party

2 WEEKS AHEAD — COLLEGE RADIO

Mail hard-copy CD's to all college radio stations at once 2 weeks ahead of the release.

RELEASE DATE / RELEASE PARTY — HOLY THE DAY HAS COME

The day your album releases, sit next to your computer with phone in hand responding to and interacting with your fans and media. PLAY LIKE HELL (at your release party – show them what you're made of). Then, celebrate!